

Sea snails and clams

The shallow seabed is teeming with invertebrates—animals that do not have internal skeletons with backbones. Many are mollusks—marine relatives of slugs and snails. Some are very snail-like, with coiled shells and obvious heads and tails. Others such as clams and mussels do not have heads or tails, and their bodies are hidden inside two hinged shells.

UNIQUE SHELL

Many sea snails have decorative shells. But one of the most spectacular and unique shells belongs to the tropical Venus comb, which is covered with needlelike spines that may help protect it from its enemies. It hunts other mollusks, sniffing them out with its long, tubular snout.



FILTER FEEDERS

Aside from gastropods, the other main group of marine mollusks are bivalves—clams, mussels, and scallops. These have two hinged shells, and live by filtering edible particles from water that they draw through their bodies. Most live in one place, buried in soft seabeds or attached to rocks.

◀ FAN MUSSEL

This big fan-shaped bivalve can be up to 47 in (120 cm) high. It lives in the Mediterranean Sea, with its pointed end buried in the seabed.

STOMACH CRAWLERS

Sea snails seem to crawl on their stomachs, just like garden snails and slugs, and because of this they are called gastropods, which means “stomach foot.” Some use their rasping tongues to graze on algae, but others such as the bubble snail are active hunters that attack and eat prey, including marine worms.



▲ DISTINCTIVE SHELL

Easily identified because of its red-lined shell, the bubble snail is found in the Indian and Pacific oceans. If threatened, the snail quickly withdraws into its shell.

